VANDERBILT UNIVERSITY

MANAGER VOYAGE · THE FOUR-WEEK COHORT

The Manager *Playbook*.

Your written personal operating system: how you manage, in your own words, one section a week. Started in the classroom, drafted through two remote weeks, presented at the capstone to peers and your business unit leader, and yours to keep.

NAME

TEAM AND BUSINESS UNIT

HOURLY, SALARIED, OR MIXED · HOW MANY PEOPLE

WEEK ONE DATE

Vanderbilt University · People, Culture and Belonging · Futures Learning Hub

READ FIRST

How this Playbook works

The cohort builds on Manager Foundations. It does not reteach the Vanderbilt Manager Standard; it practices it with your own team, and this Playbook is where the practice gets written down. One section a week, presented whole in week four.

The four weeks

WEEK 1 · IN THE CLASSROOM · 3 HOURS

What it means to manage

Expectation 03, make things better.
Section 1 · Manager Philosophy

WEEK 2 · VIRTUAL · 1.5 HOURS

Goals, 1:1s, and difficult conversations

Expectation 01, get the work done, through your team.
Section 2 · 1:1 framework and conversation plan

WEEK 3 · VIRTUAL · 1.5 HOURS

Coaching and mentoring

Expectation 02, take care of your people.
Section 3 · Delegation and growth plan

WEEK 4 · IN THE CLASSROOM · 2 HOURS

Performance, talent, and your Playbook

Expectation 04, connect your team to the rest of Vanderbilt.
Section 4 · Performance practice, and the whole Playbook

What you write, week by week

WHEN	SECTION	DUE
Before week 1	**Set your team** on the cohort site, finish Manager Foundations, and take the four-question pulse. The cohort site is at manager-voyage.vercel.app/cohort/.	Bring the printed Playbook to week 1
Week 1	**Section 1 · Manager Philosophy.** The best manager you ever had, your career on a line, what your team can expect from you, what you say when bad news lands, and your intent for the next 90 days.	Sunday
Week 2	**Section 2 · 1:1 framework and conversation plan.** Your cadence and agenda, three goals per person this quarter, and the opening sentence of the conversation you are holding.	Sunday
Week 3	**Section 3 · Delegation and growth plan.** For each person: where they want to be, one stretch assignment, their rung on the delegation ladder and the next one.	Sunday
Week 4	**Section 4 · Performance practice, and the whole Playbook.** How you run the cycle, your feedback approach, the Integrated Management Model, and the Team Development Plan.	Before the capstone

Three rules for writing it

> **Write in your own voice.** This is not a form for PCB; it is the document you will reread in month six. **Use real names and real dates.** A plan without a name and a date is a wish. **Short beats complete.** One true sentence per prompt is enough; the room adds the rest. **Weeks two and three are capped at ninety minutes,** and five of those are for this Playbook; the rest of the week is for doing it with your team.

ON YOUR OWN, ABOUT TWENTY MINUTES

W0 Before week one

Set your team on the cohort site so every scenario is written for the people you manage. Then the pulse, and one sentence.

Your team

The area your team is in
Dining, IT, facilities, a research lab, the library, student affairs, administration, advancement.

Hourly, salaried, or mixed, and how many

The first sentence of your Philosophy
What can your team expect from you? One sentence. It will be sharpened in week 1.

The pulse, before

How confident are you in each conversation today? Circle one. You answer the same four questions again in week four.

CONVERSATION	NOT YET			CONFIDENT	
Telling a team member what I expect, by when, and what good looks like	1	2	3	4	5
Holding a difficult conversation about missed work without hinting	1	2	3	4	5
Handing over a real decision, with the boundary stated, and not taking it back	1	2	3	4	5
Having a performance conversation that is honest about the answer and specific about what changes it	1	2	3	4	5

Before week one

- [ ] Manager Foundations finished, and the assessment taken
- [ ] Your team set on the cohort site (profile: area, hourly or salaried, size, where they sit)
- [ ] This Playbook printed, or open on a tablet
- [ ] The first sentence above written and ready to read aloud

> **Which of the four expectations did your assessment say to start with?** 01 Get the work done, through your team (Yukl: task) · 02 Take care of your people (relations) · 03 Make things better (change) · 04 Connect your team to the rest of Vanderbilt (external). Name it here; it becomes your thread through the four weeks.

REFERENCE · THE COHORT SITE HAS THE FULL VERSION

The other things you manage

Timecards, leave, expenses, hiring, the performance cycle, the inbox. By cadence, with the system and who to call. Then your week.

Every week

WHAT	SYSTEM	WHO TO CALL
Approve timecards and time-off requests	UKG for hourly staff; Oracle Cloud for exempt time off	Your HCM for anything that does not look right
Hold the 1:1s	The calendar, as recurring holds	Nobody. This one is yours.
Clear the approvals in Oracle HCM	Oracle HCM, your team view and worklist	Your HCM
Look back, fifteen minutes	The team meeting, or Friday on your own	Nobody

The same day it comes up

WHAT	SYSTEM	WHO TO CALL
Someone mentions leave, health, family, or FMLA	Origami, for FMLA and leave requests	Leave and Workers' Compensation, the same day; then tell your HCM
Someone is hurt at work	The workplace injury report	Leave and Workers' Compensation, the same day; then your HCM
A request for an accommodation	The interactive process	Equal Opportunity and Access
A report of discrimination, harassment, or sexual misconduct	A report to EOA or the Title IX Office	EOA, or the Title IX Office; then your HCM

Every month

WHAT	SYSTEM	WHO TO CALL
Approve expense reports and procurement requests	Oracle Cloud expenses and procurement	Your finance partner, before you approve something you do not understand
A budget check with your finance partner	A standing thirty minutes	Your finance partner, by name
Thank someone by name for a specific thing	Out loud, in front of the team, or in writing	Nobody

Each cycle

WHAT	SYSTEM	WHO TO CALL
The performance cycle: goals, check-ins, the review	Oracle HCM performance	Your HCM for the dates; your Engagement Consultant for a hard one
Hiring: the requisition, interviews, the offer	Oracle Recruiting	Your HCM opens it with you
Onboarding a new hire	The first-week checklist	Your HCM for systems access
A performance concern that a talk did not fix	Documentation, then the written step	Your HCM first; Employee Relations before any formal step
Required compliance training, yours and the team’s	Oracle Learning	Compliance, for policy questions

REFERENCE · COVEY, DRUCKER, GROVE

A week that works

The duties fit in the gaps if the managing goes into the calendar first. Fill in your own version.

MONDAY

Timecards and time off approved before the deadline

The three rocks for the week written down

Oracle HCM worklist cleared, fifteen minutes

TUESDAY TO THURSDAY

1:1s, thirty minutes each, theirs first

One protected half day with no meetings

Email at three fixed times, not all day

FRIDAY

The look back, fifteen minutes: what worked, what broke twice

One thank-you by name

Next week's rocks, before you leave

ANY DAY, SAME DAY

Leave, injury, accommodation, or a report: route it and tell your HCM

A date at risk: say it the day it is at risk, not the day it is missed

Five time rules

Stephen R. Covey: Quadrant two first. Important and not yet urgent is where managing happens: 1:1s, goals, the look back, the conversation you are avoiding. Put those in the calendar first. The approvals fit around them; it never works the other way round.

Peter Drucker: Know thy time. For one week, write down where the hours went. Managers who do this find a third of their week was interruptions they could batch. Then batch them: approvals at one fixed time, email at three.

Andy Grove: Leverage. Some hours change the output of one person for a day. Some change the output of a team for a quarter. A 1:1, a clear expectation, a decision handed over: high leverage. Rebuilding the report yourself: low. Spend the week on the first kind.

Paul Graham: The manager's schedule. Your day is now hour-sized blocks and other people's calendars. Protect one half day a week with no meetings for the thinking work, and tell the team it exists so they do not book it.

FranklinCovey: Big rocks. The jar, the rocks, the sand. The week's three rocks go in on Monday morning before the inbox opens. Everything else is sand and it still fits.

My week, in my own words

Which day the approvals happen, when the 1:1s sit, where the protected half day goes.

BEFORE WEEK ONE · THE OTHER HALF OF THE COHORT

Your leader, and your team's view

Two things make the practice stick: your own leader asking one question a week, and your team's anonymous view of the same ten behaviors you rated yourself on.

Your leader: fifteen minutes before week one

- [ ] Read the four expectations below. They are what your manager is being measured on, and what your manager's team will be asked about.
- [ ] Ask your manager which expectation their assessment told them to start with, and which habit they intend to keep for the four weeks.
- [ ] Tell them the one thing you would most like to see different on their team in ninety days. Keep it to a sentence; they will write it into their Playbook.
- [ ] Block the week-four capstone in your calendar now. Managers present their Playbook to peers and to you.

One question a week, from your leader

WEEK	THE QUESTION	WHY
1	**What is the sentence your team can expect from you? Say it to me.**	The Philosophy sentence. Hearing it said out loud to you is the first transfer.
2	**Which 1:1s are on the calendar now, and which difficult conversation did you hold?**	Expectation 01. If the 1:1s are not recurring holds by Friday, ask again Monday.
3	**What decision did you hand over, to whom, with what boundary? Did you take it back?**	Expectation 02. The honest answer to the last question is the one that matters.
4	**What will your team be able to do in ninety days that it cannot do today, and who owns it?**	Expectation 04 and the Team Development Plan. You will hear the answer again at the capstone; challenge one date.

Your team's view: the ten statements, from their side

Anonymous, three or more responses, before week one and again at ninety days. Answered on a five-point scale: Rarely, Sometimes, About half the time, Usually, Almost always.

1. My manager writes down our top priorities for the period, with a named owner for each, before the work starts.
2. My manager tells me what I own, by when, and what a good result looks like, and puts it in writing.
3. My manager looks at my work while it is in progress, well before it is due, so there is time to help.
4. When I am under pressure, my manager moves a deadline or a task that same week and checks back with me.
5. My manager thanks me for specific work, by name, within the week it happened.
6. Before my manager changes how we work, they ask for my view and it shapes the decision.
7. When a change is coming, my manager explains the reason in their own words before the official announcement reaches us.
8. After a large piece of work, my manager holds a short look-back with us: what worked, what did not, what we change.
9. My manager watches what is coming from the rest of Vanderbilt so we hear it from them first.

10. When another office asks too much of us, my manager shows the hours, names the conflict, and offers options instead of just saying yes.

WEEK 1 · IN THE CLASSROOM · WHAT IT MEANS TO MANAGE · DUE SUNDAY

01 Manager Philosophy

One page on how you will manage. It starts with the mission, runs through your Manager Voyage on a timeline, and ends with the sentence you read aloud to your four.

The best manager I ever had did...

What they did that stuck with you, and how it shows up in the way you will lead.

The mission needs my team to...

From the first fifteen minutes. What your team makes possible for the people this university exists for.

My voyage, in seven lines

STOP	ONE LINE
Before The work you were hired to do	
Day 1 The one change	
Day 7 Manager Foundations	
Day 60 Measured against the standard	
Today The cohort	
Day 90 The reassessment	
Year one Your team's year	

My career on a line, then two stops ahead

YEAR	KIND	ONE LINE

What my team can expect from me

One sentence, then the three commitments behind it. The ones you could be held to on a bad day.

What I say when bad news lands

Your first sentence, word for word.

The expectation my team needs most this month, and the habit I will keep

From the How to lead activity.

My intent for the next 90 days, and the assessment statement I want to move

What will be true about this team by Day 90 that is not true today? Which of the ten statements will say so?

> **Read it to your four.** They make it shorter and more specific, something your team could check. Write the sharpened sentence here.

02 1:1 framework and conversation plan

Expectation 01, get the work done through your team: a cadence on the calendar, goals per person, and the hard conversation you rehearsed with Dev on your phone and then held for real.

My 1:1 framework

Cadence and length
Weekly or biweekly, how long, which day. It goes on the calendar before Monday.

Where the agenda lives
Theirs first. Where it is written so both of you can see it.

What I check every time
Work before it is due, what they are stuck on, what is coming that they should hear from me first.

What I never let a 1:1 become
A status report, a one-way download, a skipped meeting.

Three goals per person, this quarter

NAME	GOAL 1	GOAL 2	GOAL 3	BY WHEN

The conversation plan

Who, and what I noticed
The specific observation, with dates. Not a feeling about them.

What I expect, by when
Clear is kind. The expectation and the date, said out loud.

My opening sentence, word for word

What they might need from me

The question you will ask, and the help you can actually give.

What happened when I held it

Fill in after. What you said, what they said, what you would say differently. You will read it back in week four.

WEEK 3 · REMOTE, UNDER NINETY MINUTES · COACHING AND MENTORING · DUE SUNDAY

03 Delegation and growth plan

Expectation 02, take care of your people. From directing to developing: where each person wants to go, one stretch assignment toward it, the rung of the ladder they are on, and the decision you handed over this week.

The delegation ladder

1 · Do as I say	2 · Check with me	3 · Tell me, then act	4 · Act, then tell me	5 · Their call
I decide, they do.	They propose, I approve.	They decide and inform me first.	They decide and inform me after.	They decide; I hear about it if it matters.

Growth plan, one line per person

NAME	WHERE THEY WANT TO BE IN TWO YEARS	ONE STRETCH ASSIGNMENT TOWARD IT	RUNG TODAY	NEXT RUNG	BY WHEN

The decision I handed over this week

The decision, and to whom

The decision, not just the task.

The one boundary I stated

The thing the decision has to respect, said once, up front.

What happened when I did not take it back

Include the moment you wanted to.

My coaching cadence

When you ask instead of tell: which meeting, how often, with the questions to hand.

One thank-you, by name, this week

Who, for what specific thing, and where you said it.

04 Performance practice

Expectation 04, connect your team to the rest of Vanderbilt. How you run the cycle, how you give feedback, and how you handle a concern from the first conversation to the written step, with the people you call along the way.

How I run the performance cycle

Goals set and written
When in the cycle, and where the team can see them.

Check-ins
How often the goals come up before the review, so nothing at the review is a surprise.

My feedback approach

Situation, behavior, impact: my template
When you did X in Y, the effect was Z. Write the version you will actually say.

Reinforcing feedback, that week
Specific, by name, the same week. How you will make sure it happens.

A concern, from first conversation to written step

STEP	WHAT I DO	WHO I CALL
The clear conversation		Nobody yet, unless unsure: my HCM
If it does not change		My HCM, before anything formal
The written step		Employee Relations Consultant, through my HCM
A leave, health, or fairness mention along the way		Leave, EOA, or Title IX the same day

The performance conversation I rehearsed with Marcus, then held
Honest about the cycle, specific about what would change the answer, a growth move that starts now.

CAPSTONE DELIVERABLE · ONE PAGE

Integrated Management Model

How the four weeks connect for you. Synthesis, not attendance: one habit per job, in your words, and the sentence at the center that holds them together.

TASK-ORIENTED · GET THE WORK DONE, THROUGH YOUR TEAM

Plan it, say it, check it, fix it

My habit, and the week it comes from:

RELATIONS-ORIENTED · TAKE CARE OF YOUR PEOPLE

Listen and help, grow them, thank them, trust them

My habit, and the week it comes from:

CHANGE-ORIENTED · MAKE THINGS BETTER

Explain the why, describe where we are going, let people try, look back

My habit, and the week it comes from:

EXTERNAL · CONNECT YOUR TEAM

Know the people, watch for what is coming, speak up for your team

My habit, and the week it comes from:

THE SENTENCE AT THE CENTER

How I manage, in one sentence. It should sound like the Philosophy from week 1, sharpened by three more weeks.

CAPSTONE DELIVERABLE · 90 DAYS

Team Development Plan

A plan for your actual team: names, goals, growth moves, and dates. Challenged by your four in week 4, one goal, one move, one date; presented in the same hour to peers and your business unit leader.

The team goal for the next 90 days

One outcome the whole team owns, and how you will know.

NAME	THEIR GOAL	GROWTH MOVE	BY DAY 30	BY DAY 60	BY DAY 90

What I need from my business unit leader

The ask, with the reason. Bring it to the capstone.

What could get in the way

The risk you already see, and your first move on it.

The five-minute presentation

- [ ] One minute: the sentence at the center, my Philosophy from week 1
- [ ] Two minutes: the team goal, how it serves the mission line, and one person's plan by name
- [ ] One minute: the habit I kept, which expectation it serves, and what the team noticed
- [ ] One minute: what I need from my business unit leader
- [ ] Then three minutes of challenge: one goal, one move, one date

WEEK 4 · IN THE CLASSROOM · TWO HOURS

The capstone, and after

Before you present, take the pulse again and compare it with your answers from before week one. Then the 90-day reassessment date.

The pulse, after

CONVERSATION	NOT YET			CONFIDENT	
Telling a team member what I expect, by when, and what good looks like	1	2	3	4	5
Holding a difficult conversation about missed work without hinting	1	2	3	4	5
Handing over a real decision, with the boundary stated, and not taking it back	1	2	3	4	5
Having a performance conversation that is honest about the answer and specific about what changes it	1	2	3	4	5

Capstone checklist

- [ ] Sections 1 to 4 finished
- [ ] Integrated Management Model on one page
- [ ] Team Development Plan with names and dates
- [ ] Business unit leader invited to the room for the presentations
- [ ] Five-minute presentation rehearsed out loud once

After the cohort

- [ ] Reread this Playbook at Day 30 and Day 90 of the plan
- [ ] Rate the ten statements again at the 90-day reassessment and compare, expectation by expectation
- [ ] Keep the Manager Portal open: templates, policy links, and who to call

Manager _____ Business unit leader _____ Date _____

Vanderbilt University · People, Culture and Belonging · Futures Learning Hub. The Manager Playbook is the manager's own document. The Playbook itself is not collected; what you present in week four is the record.